



YESTERDAY ONCE MORE

There is a sense of *deja vu* as regional chieftains again join hands to offer an alternative to the Congress and the BJP

■ By Amarnath K. Menon

Their names are familiar and so are their faces. Some old and tired, others fresh and raring for a fight. They come from different corners of the country but share a desire to break the mould of national politics. These leaders are coming together for the preparation of the next Lok Sabha elections, amid widespread optimism that regional parties will play a crucial role in the country's politics. National parties, like the Congress and the BJP, are losing their support base and turning towards the regional parties, not merely as coalition partners but as proactive players who are influencing national policies, at large.

In the absence of a formal christening, the combine is conveniently referred to as the Third Front. But with two meetings in Hyderabad and Chennai this month, it has raised

expectations of making a rich offering of promises and policies to impress the electorate soon. Their credentials are impressive, though being politicians they stand discredited every now and then. There are five former chief ministers among them—Mulayam Singh Yadav (Uttar Pradesh), Om Prakash Chautala (Haryana), S. Bangarappa (Karnataka), J. Jayalalithaa (Tamil Nadu) and N. Chandrababu Naidu (Andhra Pradesh). Already the front has eight parties—Asom Gana Parishad (AGP), All India Anna Dravida Munnetra Kazhagam, Indian National Lok Dal (INLD), Jharkhand Vikas Morcha (JVM), Kerala Congress(J), Marumalarchi Dravida Munnetra Kazhagam (MDMK), Samajwadi Party and Telugu Desam Party (TDP). The leaders are hoping that more will join soon.

Of immediate interest is the role that they would play in the presidential

elections due in July. In the electoral college that comprises MPs and MLAs from all the states, the Third Front commands less than 10 per cent of the votes. While trying to show that it is not a notional front, the new entity is upping its stakes in the presidential polls by trying to draw the Left and other parties, which who are the possible allies for the 2009 general elections. "We are certain that the Left will come with us by the time of the elections and therefore we are trying for a more widely acceptable choice of a candidate," explains Naidu. If it does not work out, as is being planned by fielding a strong contender, the emerging coalition will in all probability make its presence felt by abstaining from voting in the presidential polls.

In a distinct break from the past, this network of regional parties is working towards an alternative economic policy. The TDP is the first to moot the idea for such a policy at its annual convention held in Tirupati last month, which is still in the works. What